

Session 20: God's Covenant With Noah

Key Takeaways

- God prohibits consuming blood to remind people that all life ultimately belongs to God.
- A covenant is an external mechanism used to bind together a relationship that has been broken.

God Provides Food and Prohibits Bloodshed: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 9:1-7

¹ And Elohim blessed Noah and his sons
and he said to them,
“ **Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the land** .

a ² The **fear of you** and the terror of **you** will be
b **upon every living creature of the land**
and upon every bird of the skies;
with everything that creeps on the ground,
and with all the fish of the sea;
a' into **your hand they are given** ;
b ³ **every creeper that is living** ,
for you it will be for eating ,
a' **I give all to you** , as I gave the green plant.

a ⁴ Only the flesh with its **life** , **its blood** , you will **not eat** ;
⁵ indeed, **I will require** your **life-blood** ;
b **from every beast I will require** it,
b' and **from every human** ,
from a man's brother ,
b'' **I will require** the **life** of a human.
a' ⁶ He who **pours out** the **blood** of a **human** ,
by a **human** will his **blood** be **poured out** ,
because in the image of God he made humanity.

⁷ **And as for you all, be fruitful and multiply** ;

Genesis 9:1-7. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Structural Links Between 9:1-7, 6:21, and 1:29-30

Just as God instructed Noah to prepare food for himself and the animals as they boarded the ark (in 6:21), so now God instructs Noah on the provision of food outside the ark. But notice that God's words explicitly reference his command to all humanity in Genesis 1:29-30 and indicate a new program in light of humanity's violent nature that has been revealed in the flood narrative.

Genesis 9:2-3 Instructor's Translation

² Every living creature of the land and upon every bird of the skies; with everything that creeps on the ground, and with all the fish of the sea; into your hand they are given; ³ every creeper that's living, for you it will be for food (לכם יהיה לאכלה), I give all to you, as I gave the green plant (כירק עשב נתתי).

Animals are given as food for the humans, just as the green plants were.

Genesis 6:21 Instructor's Translation

And as for you, take for yourself some of all edible-food that you will eat, and gather it to yourself; and it shall be for food for you (לך לאכלה) and for them.

Genesis 1:29-30 Instructor's Translation

²⁹ Then God said, "Behold, I have given you every plant (נתתי לכם כל עשב) yielding seed that is on the surface of all the earth, and every tree which has fruit yielding seed; to you it shall be food (לכם יהיה לאכלה) ³⁰and to every beast of the earth and to every bird of the sky and to every creature that moved on the earth which has life-being in it, every green plant for food." And it was so.

Green plants are given as food for humans and for the animals.

9:1-6 develops the themes of 1:26-30 in light of what the flood story argues about human nature. When human nature was pre-violence, a plant-based diet was the ideal. But now that humans take life, God regulates this new situation with guidelines that express the same ethical principles later found in the laws of Mount Sinai.

Genesis 1:27-30; Leviticus 17; Genesis 4

Genesis 1:28a: And God blessed them and said, "Be fruitful and multiply and fill the land"

Genesis 9:1-6

¹ And God blessed Noah and his sons and said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply and fill the land."

Restrictions on the Blood of Animals. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Genesis 1:27-30; Leviticus 17; Genesis 4	Genesis 9:1-6
Genesis 1:28b: "and subdue it and rule over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the skies and over every living creatures that creeps on the land."	2a "And the fear of you and the terror of you will be upon all the beast of the land and over all the birds of the skies, over all that creeps the ground and over all the fish of the sea."
Genesis 1:29-30: Then God said, "Behold, I have given you every plant (כל עשב) yielding seed that is on the surface of all the earth, and every tree which has fruit yielding seed; to you it shall be food (לכם יהיה לאכלה) and to every beast of the earth and to every bird of the sky and to every thing that moves on the earth which has life-being in it, every green plant for food"; and it was so.	2b-3 "Into your hands they are given (בידכם נתנו). Every creeping thing, which has life, to you it will be for food (לכם יהיה לאכלה), just as I gave to you the green plant (כירק עשב נתתי לכם)."
Lev 17:11-13: "For the life of flesh is in its blood , and I have given it to you (נתתי לכם) upon the altar to atone (לכפר על נפשתיכם) for your lives, for the blood that is in the life atones. Therefore I said ... ' No living being among you shall eat the blood. '" Genesis 3 "you shall not eat"	4 "Surely you shall not eat flesh with its life, its blood. "
Genesis 4:8: Cain murders " his brother " (אחיו) Genesis 4:23: Lemek murders " a man " (איש)	5 "Surely ... I will require your blood which is your life from every beast I will require it and from the hand of a man (איש), his brother (אחיו), I will require the life of human.
Genesis 1:27: God created human in his own image, in the image of God he created him ; male and female he created them.	6 Whoever sheds human blood, by human his blood shall be shed, for in the image of God he made human.
<i>Restrictions on the Blood of Animals.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Humanity's rule over the animals in Eden was conducted in the context of peaceful relations with them (Gen. 2:18-20). Now in the post-flood reality, a violent and bloodthirsty humanity rules the animals. The animals will see such humans as a source of fear and threat, and so human rule over them will be an exercise of fear (Gen. 9:2a).

Links in Genesis 9:2-3

This threatening human rule over the animals is related to the fact that humans want to eat the animals, and so God grants this as a concession. This is presented here in comparison to and as a lessening of the vegan garden ideal of Genesis 1:29-30.

"In [Genesis 1] creation account, only a vegetarian diet is mentioned either for humans or animals (Gen. 1:29-30). In the paradise story the first human's relationship to the animals certainly expresses authority, but the question is of companionship, not of eating them (Gen. 2:19). After the flood, the situation has changed. Noah offers animals and birds in sacrifice (Gen. 8:20). In Genesis 9:2-7, God reaffirms the grant of sovereignty over animals and birds, but from now on they are to be under the 'fear and dread' of humankind. As God originally gave all plants to humans for food, now he gives them all that moves, subject only to the prohibition of eating blood ... The effect of this passage immediately preceding the formal promise of God's covenant with both humans and animals is that mutual relationships between creatures of the earth are now envisaged as they are, not as they were idealized in Genesis 1 and 2, or in any other vision of universal peace. The Bible contains, in fact, two models for thinking about humans and animals: one paradisaical, the other this-worldly and realistic. The first way uses the picture of peace with and between wild animals (Isaiah 11) as a metaphor for cosmic and social peace; the second way sees peace from them as a practical aspect of desired shalom."

Murray, Robert (2007). [*The Cosmic Covenant: Biblical Themes of Justice, Peace and the Integrity of Creation*](#)." Gorgias Press. 34.

Links in Genesis 9:4

However, as soon as this concession is granted, God qualifies it. Taking the life of another creature does not mean humans are God. While humans may borrow the flesh of an animal for sustenance, they do not own the animal or its life. Thus, the life blood is not to be eaten. The concession to eat animals is marked by this prohibition of eating blood, which links forward to another concession: animal sacrifice in [Leviticus 17:11-13](#).

"It might be thought that the eating of blood would be so naturally repulsive as not to require legal proscription, but the history of the subject discredits such a notion. The frequency with which the prohibition is repeated in the Torah legislation testifies to the attractiveness of the practice in ancient times. Its appeal lay in the premise, explicated in Leviticus 17:11, 14 and [Deuteronomy 12:23](#), that the blood constituted the life-essence. Consequently, popular thought had it that one could renew or reinforce one's vitality through its absorption of blood. For this reason, blood played an important role in the cults of the dead in the ancient world. In the Torah, however, precisely because blood is the symbol of life, it belongs to God alone, as does life itself."

Sarna, Nahum M. (2001). [*The JPS Torah Commentary: Genesis*](#)." Jewish Publication Society. 61.

Links in Genesis 9:5-6

This prohibition leads to a wider reflection on the nature of life: All life, animal and human, belongs to God, and so humans are responsible to God for how they treat life. Animal life and human life must be honored as sacred because God is their source.

God's Covenant With Noah and All Creation: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 9:8-17

8 **And Elohim said to Noah** and to his sons **with him** , saying,

9 “And I myself, behold, **I set up my covenant** **with y'all**,
and with your seed after you;

10 and **with every living creature** that is **with you** ,
the birds, the beasts, and every **living creature** of the land **with you** ;
from everything that comes out of the ark,
even every **living creature** of the land.

11 And **I set up my covenant with y'all**;
and never again will **all flesh** **be cut off by the waters of the flood** ,
and never again will there be a flood to ruin the land .”

12 **And Elohim said** ,

“This is **the sign of the covenant** which I am giving
between me and between you
and between every living creature that is **with you** , for everlasting generations;

13 I give **my bow in the cloud** ,
and it will be for **a sign of a covenant**
between me and between the land;

14 and it will come about when **I cloud a cloud** over the land,
that **it will be seen** , **the bow in the cloud** ,

15 and **I will remember** **my covenant**,
which is **between me and between you**
and between every living creature of all flesh ;
and never again will the waters become a flood to ruin all flesh .

16 And **the bow is in the cloud** ,
then **I will see it** ,
to remember **the everlasting covenant**
between Elohim and between every living creature,
with all flesh that is on the land.”

17 **And Elohim said to Noah** ,

“This is **the sign of the covenant which I have set up**
between me and all flesh that is on the land.”

Genesis 9:8-17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

This is the first formal covenant speech and ceremony in the Hebrew Bible. It sets the design pattern for all future covenants that God makes with Abraham ([Gen. 15](#); [Gen. 17](#)), the Israelites ([Exod. 19-24](#)), Phineas ([Num. 25](#)), and David ([2 Sam. 7](#)). It also sets the terms for the prophetic hope of the new covenant ([Ezek. 36](#); [Jer. 31](#); [Isa. 54-55](#)).

Literary Design and Main Theme

Gordon Wenham points out in his book *Genesis 1-15* that God’s covenant speech is designed in three movements, and the first and last movements form an introductory and concluding frame around the substance of the speech in the center (Wenham, 1987).

The covenant between God and all creation, mankind, and the animals is confirmed by God putting the rainbow in the clouds and making three speeches in verses 9-11, 12-16, 17. These are arranged concentrically.

A 9:9–11	“And I will establish (הקמתי) my covenant with you and your seed ... and all living creatures”		
	B 9:12a	And God said, “This is sign (אות) of the covenant”	
		C 9:12b	my covenant “for eternal (עולם) generations”
			D 9:13–16 “my bow (קשתי) which I place in the cloud, it will be for a sign (אות) of the covenant between me and all the land”
		C’ 9:16	I will remember “eternal (עולם) covenant”
	B’ 9:17a	And God said to Noah, “This is the sign (אות) of my covenant”	
A’ 9:17b	“the covenant which I am establishing (הקמתי) between me and all flesh”		
Chiasm of Genesis 9:9-17. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).			

“The first speech, vv 9-11, introduces the topic of the covenant and its content, the future stability of the cosmos. The second and most important speech, vv 12-16, equates the confirmation of the covenant with setting the rainbow in the clouds. The sign of the covenant is its confirmation. The third and final speech, v 17, sums up the significance of the whole event.”

Wenham, Gordon J. (1987). [Word Biblical Commentary, Vol. 1: Genesis 1-15](#). Thomas Nelson. 172-173.

Notice that the word “covenant” appears seven times.

The Cosmic Covenant

This is the first covenant speech and ceremony in the Hebrew Bible, and it appears after Noah’s sacrifice. Noah’s sacrifice is the narrative embodiment of his obedience that releases God’s blessing into a new creation and qualifies him to intercede on behalf of creation. It is fitting, therefore, that God makes a covenant with all creation (“cosmic covenant”) through a covenant with Noah.

Covenant (Heb. *berit* / ברית)

“A solemn commitment of oneself to undertake an obligation.”

Waltke, Bruce K. (2001). [Genesis: A Commentary](#). Zondervan Academic. 287.

“A covenant is an enduring agreement which defines a relationship between two parties involving a solemn, binding obligation on one or both parties, made by oath under threat of divine curse, and ratified by a visual ritual.”

Adapted from Lane, C. Daniel (2000). “*The Meaning and Use of the Old Testament Term for ‘Covenant’ (berît): with Some Implications for Dispensationalism and Covenant Theology*.” PhD diss., Trinity International University. 314.

A covenant is the formalization of a partnership between two parties so that they can accomplish or work toward a common end to each other’s benefit. The word “covenant” occurs 284 times in biblical Hebrew, clustered around certain covenant-making narratives or in texts that reference those narratives.

Covenants Between People in the Hebrew Bible

Covenant Type	Examples
International treaties	• King Solomon and King Hiram make a peace treaty and promise to share economic abundance for each other’s benefit (1 Kgs. 5:12). • Joshua and the Gibeonites make a peace treaty that exempts the Gibeonites from attack during the Israelite conquest of the land (Josh. 9:6-7, 11, 15-16).
<i>Covenants Between People in the Bible</i> . Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Covenant Type	Examples
Clan/tribal alliances	• The neighboring clans of Abraham and Mamre promise to protect each other (Gen. 14:13). • Abraham and Abimelek promise to interact with integrity after Abraham's deception regarding Sarah (Gen. 21:27, 32). • Isaac and Abimelek promise to benefit one another and do no harm (Gen. 26:28).
Personal agreements	• Jacob and Laban (Gen. 31:44) promise not to cross the Israel/Aram border to do harm.
Loyalty agreements	• Jonathan promises to protect David from his father Saul and swears loyalty to David (1 Sam. 18:3, 20:8, 23:18). • The northern tribes of Israel promise to acknowledge the Judean David as their tribal king (2 Sam. 5:3).
Marriage	• Marriage is a loyalty agreement between a man and woman (see Prov. 2:17 and Mal. 2:14).
<i>Covenants Between People in the Bible.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Covenants Between God and People in the Hebrew Bible

Covenant	Reference
Creation covenant	?
Covenant with Noah and all creation	Genesis 6:18, 9:8-17
Covenant with Abraham	Genesis 12, 15, 17, 22:15-18
Covenant with Israel	Exodus 19-24; Leviticus 26; Deuteronomy 28
Covenant with Levi	Numbers 25:6-13; Malachi 2:1-9
Covenant with David	2 Samuel 7; Psalm 89, 132
<i>Covenants Between God and People.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Covenant	Reference
The New Covenant	Jeremiah 31; Ezekiel 36
<i>Covenants Between God and People</i> . Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

“With the Noahic covenant promising the stability of the cosmic structure, the Abrahamic covenant promising people and land, the Davidic covenant promising sovereignty, and the Israelite covenant promising life, security, and prosperity, the biblical authors and editors possessed a platform from which they could portray and reconcile nearly every historical tradition, legendary, didactic, and folk account in their tradition. If we deleted all references to covenant ... we would have simply an anthology of stories. As it is, we have a structure that can house a macro-plot.”

Friedman, Richard Elliot (1987). “The Hiding of the Face: An Essay on the Literary Unity of Biblical Narrative.” Neusner, J. (Ed.) [*Judaic Perspectives on Ancient Israel*](#). Fortress Press. 215.

In every one of these covenants, God forwards his purpose to provide a seed of the woman who will restore the Eden blessing to humanity and creation. Each covenant narrows down the lineage of promise as each generation passes and/or fails the test of faithfulness to God’s purposes.

A Covenant in Eden?

Given that all post-Eden covenants include allusions back to Genesis 1-2, many traditions believe that there was a covenant in place between God and Adam and Eve that was (a) unspoken and (b) broken in Genesis 3.

The absence of the word “covenant” in Genesis 1 or 2 is conspicuous. Why isn’t the relationship between God and Adam and Eve described as a covenant? A handful of reasons suggest themselves.

If Genesis 1-2 represents a divine-human ideal, then it seems important that while it’s not called a covenant, it is described with the basic elements of a covenant. Humans are God’s royal priestly representatives (the image of God), and they are invited to trust and follow God’s command (Gen. 2:15-17). If they do, there will be eternal life, and if not, death will result.

It is only after this primordial relationship between God and humans has been violated that God begins to initiate a succession of covenants.

“Covenants served to ... offer assurances, bolster faith, and reinforce commitments. In a world not invaded by sin, there would be no need for adding oaths to commitments, no need for ‘covenants’—no more than in such a world would oaths be necessary to establish the truth of one’s ‘yes’ or ‘no’ (see [Matt. 5:34-37](#); [Jas. 5:12](#); [Heb. 6:16](#)). Biblical covenants were emergency measures occasioned by and ministering to human weakness—until the kingdom of God has fully come.”

Stek, John (1994). “‘Covenant’ Overload in Reformed Theology.” *Calvin Theological Journal* Volume 29 (1). 40.

This is slightly overstated by Stek, but he makes an essential point. The word “covenant” is absent from the Eden story because, ideally, the divine-human relationship should not need to be formalized because it should be a natural union of wills and purposes. This type of union between the divine and human wills characterizes Jesus’ relationship to the Father (see [John 5:19](#), [6:38](#), [7:16](#), [7:28](#), [8:29](#)), and it is the kind of divine-human union that was forfeited in Eden.

In this reading, the covenant is a rescue mechanism, or a means to an end. It formalizes the divine purpose into commitments, and it invites human partners to fulfill the divine will. As Jeremiah says, the new covenant will not be like the old because it will bring about a new creation, one in which the human will is made one with the divine in love and commitment ([Jer. 31:31-34](#)). In such a world, formal commitments and oaths become unnecessary.

The institution of covenant points to an Eden and new creation ideal, and it should be seen as a means to an end. That end is the union of God and humanity in love, will, and purpose. The apostle Paul calls this “the new humanity” ([Eph. 4:24](#)).

Reflection Question

How do you understand the word “covenant”? What does a covenant accomplish?